‘Oh, I’m too old to have an opinion about that.’

I’d have been happy listening to his opinion on that and anything else for the rest of the day. We all know his story but, looking into his eyes, catching his smile, following the lines across this incredibly handsome face, you couldn’t help wanting to hear it from him. I don’t think Mr Mandela would have been too sorry to spend a little while longer with us either. Time was pushing on, though, and we had work to do back in Durban. By the time we stumbled off the bus back at the hotel, having been up before dawn, our lack of sleep was starting to catch up with us. The afternoon drifted past in a dream. Meeting Nelson Mandela today: did that actually happen to me? I needed to call Victoria and tell her all about it before I could really believe it was true.

Whatever’s happening we have to touch base. Because both Victoria and I have had careers that take us away from home a lot, telephones have been a pretty big deal in our relationship down the years. When we were first getting to know one another, she was traveling all over the world with the Spice Girls. They even took a year away from England for tax reasons on the advice of their manager. That put pressure on the times we could actually be with each other. Sometimes I think we got to know each other down the phone line. I’d be in Manchester after training; Victoria would be in a hotel somewhere in the States, getting ready to go on stage at a 30,000-seat auditorium that night. I can remember days when we spent five hours on the phone at a time. You find out so much about the person you love and eventually marry in the first weeks and months after you meet her. There’s all that history, all those details, you have to fill in. Me and Victoria learned about each other long distance.

That’s carried on ever since, of course. We married, we’ve had children, but we still have to be away sometimes for weeks at a time. We’ll still talk all the time but it’s different now. For a start, we don’t mind a bit of technology: the videophones while I was out in Japan at the World Cup were just the job. And these days, of course, it’s not two single people: a boy and a girl falling in love. Whoever’s at home has got their hands full with Brooklyn and Romeo. We’ve always had fantastic support from our parents looking after the boys. But whichever one of us is at home will still be busy with mealtimes, bathtimes, bedtimes and school runs. We end up talking on the phone more often now, but not for such a long time. There’ll always be something the boys need that means: